

2026 Chocó Earthquake (Colombia)

M7.4, San José del Palmar, Chocó Department - 10 August 2026

Mww 7.4 · depth 110 km · MMI VII (Very strong) — USGS ShakeMap; the SGC macroseismic intensity map agrees · GLIDE EQ-2026-000146-COL

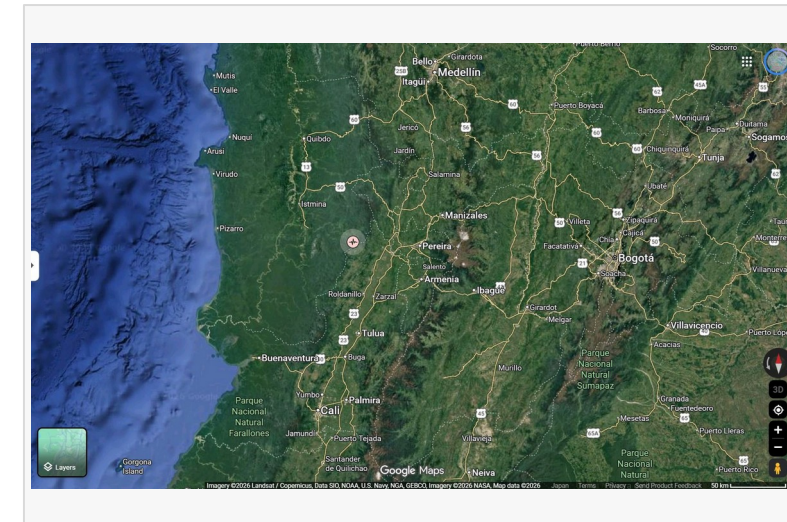
(1) World / Colombia



(2) NW South America



(3) Epicentre & affected cities

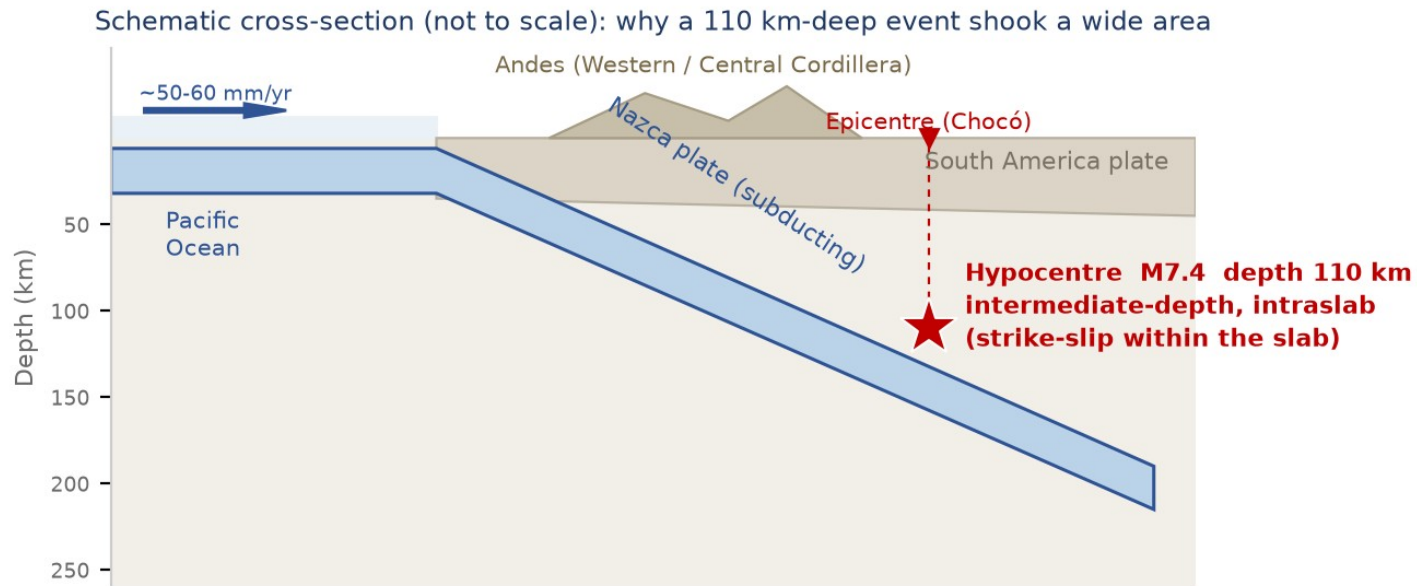


Locator maps © Google (Google Maps). Distances shown on later pages are computed from the published USGS coordinates.

Overview At 07:34 local time (12:34 UTC) on 10 August 2026, an Mww 7.4 earthquake struck western Colombia with its epicentre 5 km east of San José del Palmar in Chocó Department, at a depth of about 110 km (USGS). The event was an intermediate-depth, strike-slip rupture inside the subducting Nazca slab; because of its depth, strong shaking (MMI VI-VII) was spread over a wide area of the Andean Coffee Region rather than concentrated near the epicentre, and about 10.5 million people were exposed to it. The SGC describes it as the largest-magnitude earthquake recorded in Colombia in the past decade. The toll rose steeply through the first two days: 111 deaths in the Government's 13:00 COT balance on 10 August, 132 by that evening, and 182 deaths with 2,542 injured and 189 missing in UNGRD's situation report on 11 August, against 240 deaths when the departmental and city announcements are added up — more than 1,600 buildings damaged (1,575 homes damaged, 37 destroyed, 61 buildings collapsed), together with damage to 18 health facilities, 52 educational facilities, 18 major roads and six regional airports. The passenger terminal of Matecaña International Airport in Pereira partially collapsed, a tower of the neo-Gothic cathedral in Manizales fell onto the nave, and about 30% of the University Hospital in Cali collapsed. The President declared a national disaster, set up a Unified Command Post in Chocó and deployed four USAR teams and the armed forces. There was no tsunami. All figures are preliminary and are expected to change as assessment proceeds.

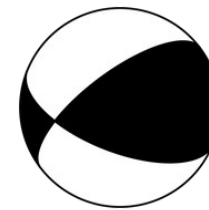
Sources: [USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia \(event page\)](#) · [SGC — event bulletin SGC2026pqmqmro \(this earthquake\)](#) · [UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management](#) · [Google Maps](#)

Seismotectonic Setting: an intraslab earthquake



Schematic cross-section (ADRC)

Colombia lies at the junction of the Nazca, Caribbean and South America plates. Off the Pacific coast the Nazca plate subducts eastward beneath South America at roughly 50-60 mm/yr, and the descending slab reaches intermediate depths (70-300 km) beneath the Western and Central Cordilleras. This event ruptured inside that slab at about 110 km depth, which is why the shaking was felt over hundreds of kilometres - as far as Bogotá, Quito and Panamá City - while surface faulting and tsunami generation were absent. Intermediate-depth events radiate high-frequency energy efficiently and attenuate slowly, so damage tends to be distributed across many cities rather than concentrated in a narrow epicentral zone.



Focal mechanism (beachball)

Both agencies report a strike-slip mechanism.

[Official] Depth about 110 km (USGS, revised): an intraslab event, not a plate-interface megathrust.

[Official] Strike-slip mechanism within the descending Nazca slab (USGS tectonic summary).

[Official] Maximum shaking MMI VII (Very strong); about 10.5 million people exposed to MMI VI-VII.

[Official] USGS PAGER (v5) Orange alert: the most likely fatality band is 1,000-10,000 and the most likely loss band USD 100-1,000 million — model estimates, not observations, and far above the figures reported so far.

[Official] The SGC assesses this as the largest-magnitude earthquake recorded in Colombia in the past decade.

[Media] Shaking was reported as unusually long in duration in cities far from the epicentre - a characteristic of deep events recorded on soft valley sediments.

[Official] The Coffee Region has a history of both deep and shallow damaging events: M7.0 at 150 km depth in 1938, M6.5 at 64 km in 1962 and M6.1 at 15 km in 1999 (SGC/GEM national hazard model).

Overview of the Earthquake & Response Measures

10 Aug 2026, 07:34 COT (12:34 UTC / 21:34 JST) | Mww 7.4 | depth 110 km | MMI VII (Very strong) — USGS ShakeMap; the SGC macroseismic intensity map agrees

Figures as of the morning of 13 Aug 2026 COT (evening JST), about 78 hours after the earthquake, from the UNGRD balance given by its director David Santiago Tamayo: 273 deaths, 3,824 injured, 377 missing, 40,753 families (97,515 people) affected, 12,584 homes destroyed and 74,873 damaged, 172 buildings collapsed. An economic emergency has been declared. All figures are preliminary.

[Official] The Government declared a national disaster (desastre nacional), enabling extraordinary mobilisation and coordination of the response.

[Official] President Abelardo de la Espriella - in office for three days - ordered a Unified Command Post (PMU) in Chocó to coordinate the emergency, and travelled to Pereira, one of the worst-hit cities.

[Official] The National Unit for Disaster Risk Management (UNGRD) activated the national system, verified damage with departmental and municipal authorities, and channelled offers of assistance together with the Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

[Official] Four USAR (urban search and rescue) groups were deployed from Bogotá, Envigado, Yopal and Medellín to reinforce search and rescue.

[Official] Soldiers were deployed to the affected departments for search, rescue and route clearance.

[Official] Civil aviation suspended flights at Pereira, Manizales, Quibdó, Armenia, Cartago and Buenaventura while runways and terminals were inspected.

[Media] Damaged buildings, power outages and communications disruption are slowing assessment in parts of Chocó closest to the epicentre.

[Official] GLIDE number assigned for this event: EQ-2026-000146-COL.

Chronology of the Response (10-13 August) (1/3)

Times are Colombia time (COT, UTC-5). The earthquake occurred at 07:34 COT = 21:34 JST on 10 August.

Time	Action	Source
07:34	Mww 7.4 earthquake, epicentre 5 km S of San José del Palmar (Chocó), depth approx. 110 km. Felt in Bogotá, Cali, Medellín, and in Ecuador, Panama and Venezuela.	USGS / SGC
07:40s	The SGC issues a first bulletin (initially M6.6, 79 km depth), later revised to M7.4 at 96 km, located with 69 stations (event SGC2026pqqmro); damage-assessment protocols activated.	SGC
Morning	UNGRD reports first damage indications in 9 municipalities of Chocó, 8 of Caldas, 2 of Valle del Cauca and 2 of Risaralda, plus localities in Quindío.	UNGRD
Morning	Cali reports collapsed structures at 12 critical points with people trapped; part of the University Hospital collapses.	Mayor of Cali
Morning	Manizales reports 17 buildings collapsed and 19 partially collapsed; a tower of the neo-Gothic cathedral falls onto the nave. Residents asked to stay outdoors because of aftershocks.	Mayor of Manizales
Morning	Passenger terminal of Matecaña International Airport (Pereira) partially collapses; flights suspended at six regional airports.	Aerocivil / media
Daytime	National disaster declared; Unified Command Post established in Chocó; armed forces deployed.	Government
Daytime	Four USAR teams deployed from Bogotá, Envigado, Yopal and Medellín.	UNGRD
Daytime	More than 20 aftershocks recorded; the largest widely felt aftershock is M4.8.	SGC
Daytime	President travels to Pereira to lead the response on the ground.	Presidency

Sources: [USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia \(event page\)](#) · [UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management](#) · [CNN — live updates: death toll rises to 132](#) · [Colombia One - First official assessment: widespread structural damage](#)

Chronology of the Response (10-13 August) (2/3)

Times are Colombia time (COT, UTC-5). The earthquake occurred at 07:34 COT = 21:34 JST on 10 August.

Time	Action	Source
12:13	Copernicus EMS Rapid Mapping activated as EMSR916 (17:13 UTC), requested by EC Services / DG ECHO, for earthquake damage assessment mapping.	Copernicus EMS
Afternoon	First national damage report: 111 deaths, 87 injured; 1,575 homes damaged, 37 destroyed, 61 buildings collapsed; 18 health facilities, 52 educational facilities, 17 community facilities, 18 major roads and 6 regional airports damaged.	Presidency / UNGRD
Afternoon	Ecuador mobilises a 47-person USAR team with canine units; Mexico and other governments offer assistance, to be channelled through the Foreign Ministry and UNGRD.	International media
Evening	The reported national death toll rises to 132. Four people have been rescued alive from the rubble; more than 20 municipalities are reported affected, and power and telecommunications faults continue in Chocó.	International media
11 Aug	Search continues overnight. The President reports 700 injured nationally and about 5,000 homes damaged or destroyed, declares the missing the State's priority, and orders troops to Cali to maintain order. The mayor of Cali reports 85 deaths, 885 injured and 188 missing; Pereira's fire service reports 66 deaths; about 100 people are missing in Manizales. Five capital cities - Cali, Pereira, Quibdó, Manizales and Armenia - remain on red alert.	Presidency / local authorities
11 Aug PM	UNGRD's situation report gives 182 deaths, 2,542 injured and 189 missing, with 13,067 homes damaged and 2,501 destroyed, 93 health facilities, 884 educational institutions, 427 community facilities and 77 roads affected. The President puts the toll at 181, of which 97.6% in capital cities. Ecuador, El Salvador and Russia are thanked for assistance.	UNGRD / Presidency
11 Aug PM	The SGC's published aftershock total reaches 103 at 15:00 COT - 97 at M3.0 or below, 5 between M3.0 and M4.0, one above M4.0 - and an M3.9 during the day prompts building evacuations in several affected cities. Its catalogue for the same period holds 147 located events, the wider figure including background seismicity.	SGC
11 Aug 14:20 UTC	The SGC revises its solution for the mainshock to M7.4 at 103 km depth, 4.99 N 76.29 W, located with 119 stations and 208 phases. Its first bulletin had given M6.6 at 79 km and its second 7.4 at 96 km with 69 stations.	SGC
11 Aug 07:31	Japan's Prime Minister posts condolences (21:31 JST) and Foreign Minister Motegi issues a message offering condolences and stating that the Government of Japan also stands ready to provide the necessary assistance and that Japan stands in strong solidarity with the people of Colombia.	Japan (MOFA)
12 Aug	Cali city officials report 107 buildings collapsed, 643 with structural damage and 18 under evacuation order; 230 people trapped, 88 rescued, 69 dead and 1,008 injured in the city.	Mayor of Cali

Sources: [USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia \(event page\)](#) · [UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management](#) · [CNN — live updates: death toll rises to 132](#) · [Colombia One - First official assessment: widespread structural damage](#)

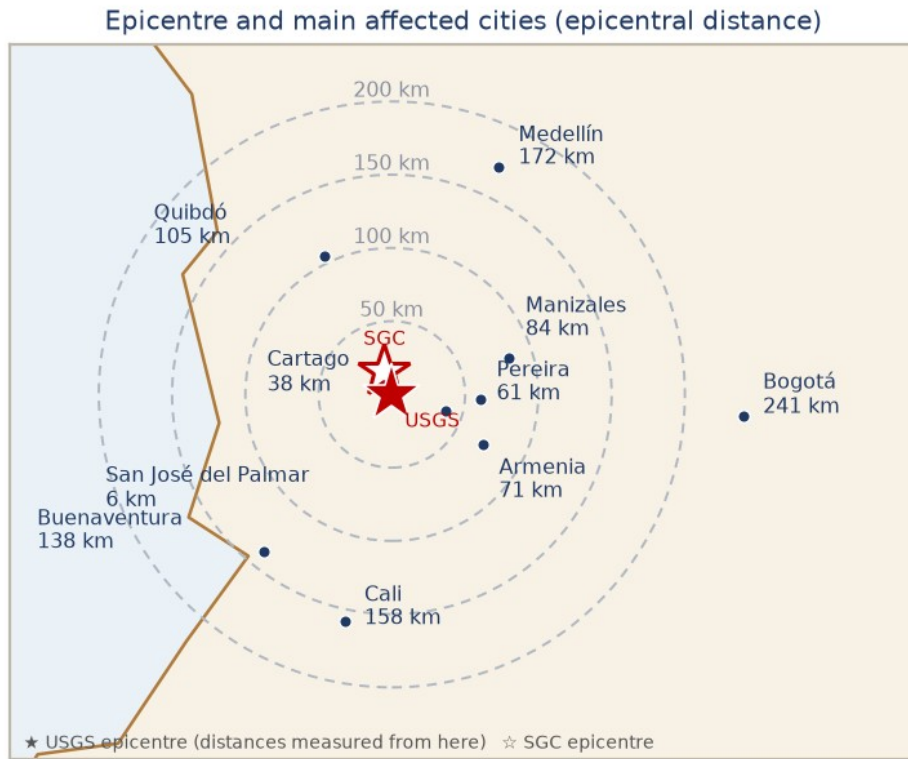
Chronology of the Response (10-13 August) (3/3)

Times are Colombia time (COT, UTC-5). The earthquake occurred at 07:34 COT = 21:34 JST on 10 August.

Time	Action	Source
11 Aug	OCHA states the humanitarian system is ready to support Colombia and names drinking water, hygiene and household items, health, food and shelter as the priority needs; no formal request for assistance has been received from the Colombian authorities.	UN / OCHA
12 Aug	The provisional national balance passes 224 deaths and more than 2,500 injured, with 279 taken to hospital and 243 people rescued alive; 195 are reported missing to the authorities. The citizen platform “Colombia te busca” holds 4,084 registrations, 3,653 of them still unresolved. Search continues in Pereira with about 300 rescuers, and much of Chocó remains reachable only by boat or aircraft.	Government
12 Aug	The President tours Pereira, Dosquebradas, Manizales and Armenia after Quibdó and Cali, announcing three months of relief on utility bills for affected households, rent subsidies for those who lost their homes and a shock plan for education and housing; an economic emergency decree is being prepared.	Presidency
12 Aug	UNGRD's consolidated report covers 14 departments and 403 municipalities: 239 deaths, 3,755 injured, 287 missing, 140 buildings collapsed, 24,324 families (49,214 people) affected, 9,215 homes destroyed and 45,457 seriously damaged. Colombia accepts INSARAG-classified USAR teams from Israel, Ecuador, El Salvador and the United States; El Salvador sends 100 tonnes of relief supplies. A woman is rescued in Pereira after 36 hours under the rubble.	UNGRD
12 Aug	Adding up the departmental and city announcements gives 254 deaths - Pereira 101, Cali 95 - ahead of the national consolidation, which media attribute to the central government being slower to update.	International media
12 Aug PM	From the Palacio de San Carlos the President announces UNGRD's updated balance: 265 deaths, 3,494 injured, 496 missing, 25,872 families (53,816 people) affected, 11,347 homes destroyed and 53,526 damaged, 1,819 educational centres and 631 community facilities affected. He also announces the declaration of an economic emergency.	Presidency
13 Aug 09:42	An M4.2 aftershock strikes San José del Palmar at 95 km depth, about 20 km from the mainshock epicentre. Felt in Pereira, Manizales, Medellín and Bogotá; search-and-rescue work is halted temporarily. It is the second aftershock above M4.0.	SGC
13 Aug AM	UNGRD's director gives a new balance: 273 dead, 3,824 injured, 377 missing, 40,753 families (97,515 people) affected, 12,584 homes destroyed and 74,873 damaged, 172 buildings collapsed, 2,198 educational and 825 community facilities, 216 health facilities, 71 aqueducts, 29 banking offices and five airports. Medicina Legal has received 250 bodies, 227 recognised. Red alert continues in Cali, Pereira, Quibdó, Manizales and Armenia.	UNGRD

Sources: [USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia \(event page\)](#) · [UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management](#) · [CNN — live updates: death toll rises to 132](#) · [Colombia One - First official assessment: widespread structural damage](#)

Affected Departments & Cities



Epicentral distances (ADRC)

Why damage is dispersed

A 110 km-deep source puts every city in the region at a broadly similar hypocentral distance (110-205 km), so no single city sits in a narrow zone of extreme shaking.

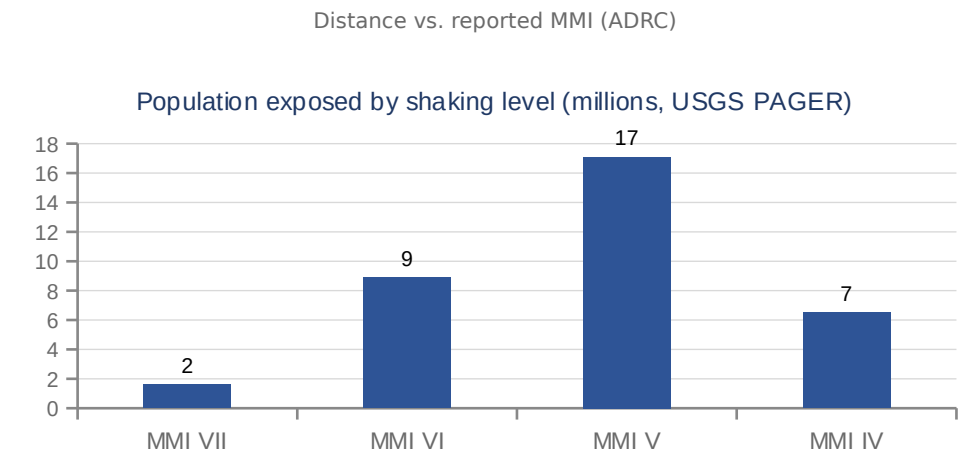
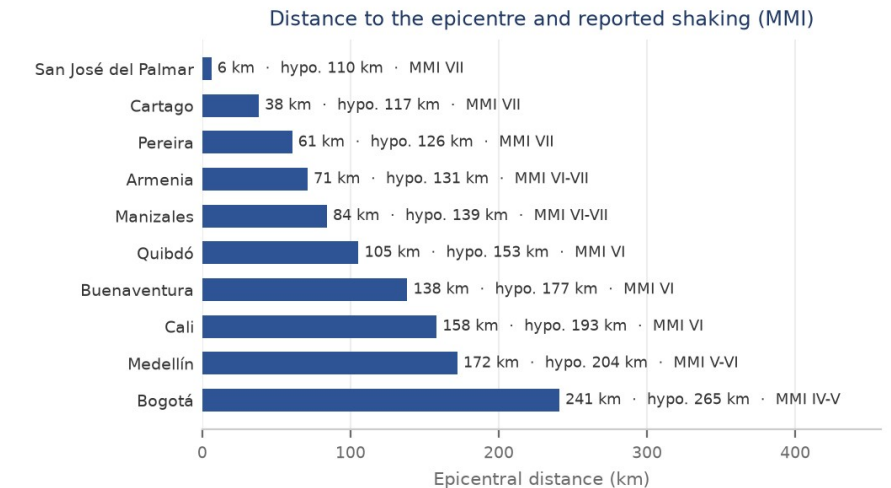
Department	Main cities	Dist.	MMI	Situation
Chocó	San José del Palmar / Quibdó	6 / 105 km	VII / VI	Epicentral department; 9 municipalities with reported damage; access, power and communications constrained.
Risaralda	Pereira, Dosquebradas	61 km	VII	Highest reported death toll (at least 40; the governor cites at least 42). Airport terminal partially collapsed.
Valle del Cauca	Cali, Cartago, Buenaventura	158 / 38 / 138 km	VI-VII	27 deaths reported; 25-30 collapsed structures at 12 critical points in Cali; University Hospital heavily damaged.
Caldas	Manizales	84 km	VI-VII	8 municipalities affected; 17 buildings collapsed and 19 partially collapsed in Manizales; cathedral tower fell onto the nave.
Quindío	Armenia and other localities	71 km	VII	Several localities reported affected; the same Coffee Region devastated by the 1999 Armenia earthquake.
Antioquia	Medellín and surroundings	172 km	V-VI	One death reported (a 73-year-old); structural damage under inspection.
Cundinamarca / Bogotá	Bogotá, Nilo	241 km	IV-V	Widely felt; buildings evacuated; structural damage to a school in Nilo reported.

Event Parameters & Observed Shaking

Item	Value
Origin time (local)	10 Aug 2026, 07:34:28 COT (UTC-5)
Origin time (UTC / JST)	10 Aug 2026, 12:34:28 UTC / 10 Aug 2026, 21:34 JST
Epicentre	USGS: 5 km S of San José del Palmar, Chocó Department (approx. 280 km W of Bogotá) — SGC: 12 km from San José del Palmar
Coordinates	USGS 4.8436 N, 76.2422 W · SGC 4.99 N, 76.29 W
Magnitude	Mww 7.4 (USGS) · 7.4 (SGC)
Depth	110.3 km (USGS, PAGER v5) / 103 km (SGC, revised 11 Aug)
Mechanism	Strike-slip faulting at intermediate depth, within the subducting Nazca slab (not on the shallow plate interface)
Max. shaking	MMI VII (Very strong) — USGS ShakeMap; the SGC macroseismic intensity map agrees
Felt area	Felt across western and central Colombia including Bogotá, Cali and Medellín, and in Ecuador, Panama and Venezuela
Tsunami	No tsunami. The event was inland and at intermediate depth; no tsunami warning was issued for the Pacific coast.
Alert level	USGS PAGER: Orange (version 5). Most likely fatality band 1,000-10,000 (35% probability); economic losses most likely USD 100-1,000 million (34%), less than 1% of Colombia's GDP. GDACS: Orange.
GLIDE	EQ-2026-000146-COL

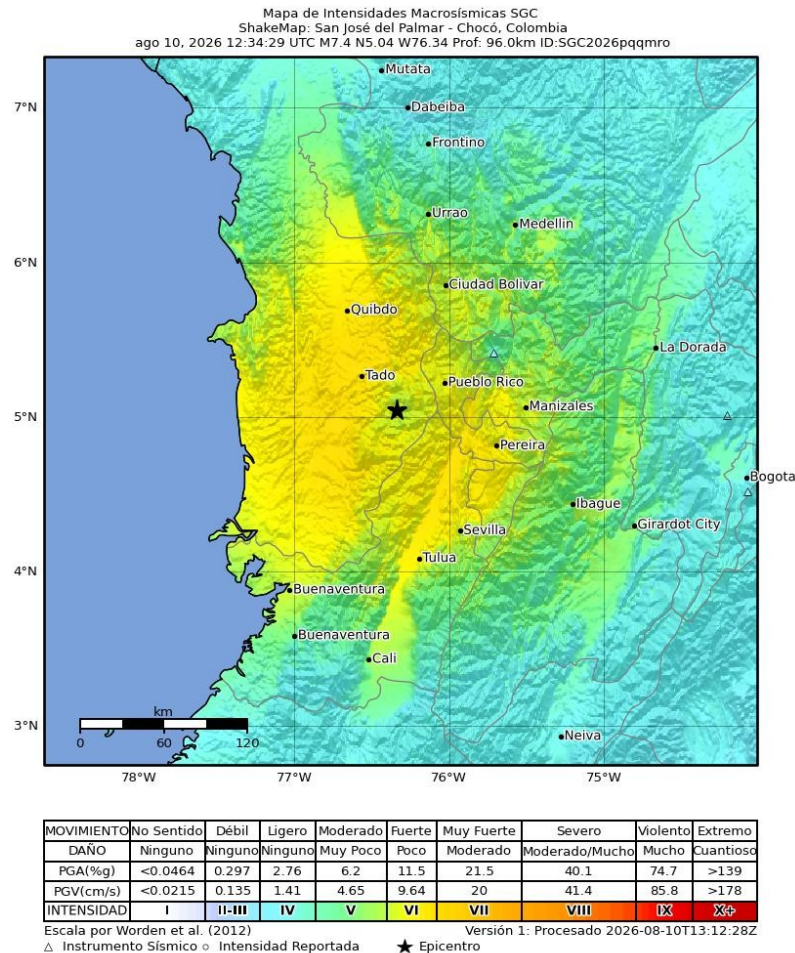
USGS and SGC agree on size. The SGC revised its solution at 14:20 UTC on 11 August to 103 km with 119 stations and 208 phases; the revised location is 17 km from the USGS one and their depths differ by 7 km, so the two have converged as more stations were read. Epicentral distances in this report are measured from the USGS location. SGC bulletins remain subject to change.

Sources: [USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia \(event page\)](#) · [SGC — event bulletin SGC2026pqmqmro \(this earthquake\)](#) · [GDACS - Orange earthquake alert, Colombia, 10 Aug 2026](#)



USGS PAGER (version 5) exposure estimates. About 10.5 million people were exposed to Strong or Very Strong shaking (MMI VI-VII) and about 34 million to MMI IV or above across four countries. These are model estimates.

Macroseismic Intensity (SGC)



ShakeMap: San José del Palmar - Chocó, Colombia · 10 Aug 2026 12:34:29 UTC · M7.4 · N5.04 W76.34 · depth 96.0 km · ID SGC2026pqmqmro · Version 1, processed 2026-08-10T13:12:28Z · scale after Worden et al. (2012)

The SGC map shows the strongest band (MMI VII, 'Muy Fuerte') over the epicentral area of Chocó and along the inter-Andean corridor through Risaralda, Caldas, Quindío and northern Valle del Cauca — the belt in which the collapses in Pereira, Manizales, Armenia and Cartago occurred. Intensity falls away eastward: Medellín and Cali sit in the moderate-to-strong bands and Bogotá, 241 km from the epicentre, in a low one. The elongated pattern along the valleys, rather than a compact circle around the epicentre, is the signature of a 96-110 km-deep source combined with soft valley sediments.

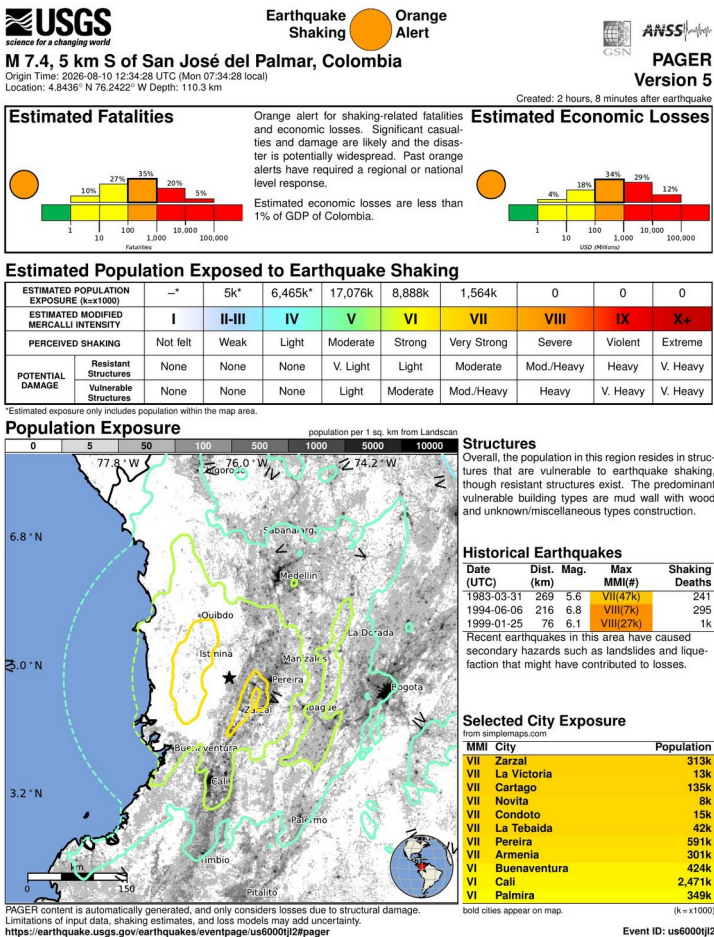
MMI	Perceived shaking	Potential damage	PGA (%g)	PGV (cm/s)
I	Not felt	None	<0.0464	<0.0215
II-III	Weak	None	0.297	0.135
IV	Light	None	2.76	1.41
V	Moderate	Very light	6.2	4.65
VI	Strong	Light	11.5	9.64
VII	Very strong	Moderate	21.5	20
VIII	Severe	Moderate/heavy	40.1	41.4
IX	Violent	Heavy	74.7	85.8
X+	Extreme	Very heavy	>139	>178

Modified Mercalli scale (Worden et al., 2012), as printed on the SGC map

Official SGC intensity map (© SGC) — <https://www.sgc.gov.co/detallesismo/SGC2026pqmqmro/mmi>

Sources: [SGC — macroseismic intensity map \(ShakeMap\) for this earthquake](#) · [SGC — event bulletin SGC2026pqmqmro \(this earthquake\)](#) · [USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia \(event page\)](#)

USGS PAGER Assessment



PAGER is the USGS rapid impact estimate, issued within minutes and revised as the event is refined; version 5 was created 2 hours 8 minutes after the earthquake. It is a probability distribution, not a forecast of a single number: the orange alert means significant casualties and damage are likely and that past orange alerts have required a regional or national response. Its most likely fatality band, 1,000-10,000, sat far above the 111 deaths reported nine hours after the event; 33 hours in the reported toll had risen to 182-240, into PAGER's 100-1,000 band, which the model gave a lower but substantial probability. The gap is normal at this stage and narrows as ground truth replaces modelled losses.

MMI	Perceived shaking	Exposed
VIII+	Severe	-
VII	Very strong	1,564k
VI	Strong	8,888k
V	Moderate	17,076k
IV	Light	6,465k

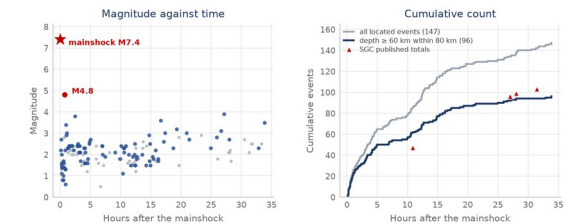
USGS PAGER (version 5) exposure estimates. About 10.5 million people were exposed to Strong or Very Strong shaking (MMI VI-VII) and about 34 million to MMI IV or above across four countries. These are model estimates.

onePAGER, version 5 (public domain, USGS)
— <https://earthquake.usgs.gov/earthquakes/eventpage/us6000tj2/pager>

Seismicity: Aftershocks

Time	Magnitude	Note	Tier
10 Aug 08:18 COT (13:18 UTC)	M4.8	The largest aftershock, 44 minutes after the mainshock: San José del Palmar, depth 94 km, 19 km from the epicentre (SGC2026pqryij). USGS catalogues the same event as mb 5.0 at 98.5 km. Widely felt.	Official
10 Aug 10:01 COT (15:01 UTC)	M3.8	San José del Palmar, depth 88 km. This is the event two regional agencies published as M4.7 in the multi-agency bulletin; the SGC solution is 0.9 units smaller.	Official
11 Aug 00:12 / 10:43 COT	M3.6 / M3.9	San José del Palmar, depths 96 km and 92 km. The 10:43 event was felt strongly enough for buildings to be evacuated in several of the affected cities.	Official
13 Aug 09:42 COT (14:42 UTC)	M4.2	San José del Palmar, depth 95 km, about 20 km from the epicentre - the same source volume as the mainshock. Felt as far as Bogotá and strong enough to halt search-and-rescue work temporarily.	Official
to 11 Aug 17:24 COT	147 located	SGC catalogue, 34 hours after the mainshock: 60 below M2.0, 76 at M2.0-2.9, 10 at M3.0-3.9, one at M4.0-4.9	Official

The SGC located 147 events in the 34 hours after the mainshock. Within that window only one exceeded M4.0 - the M4.8 that followed 44 minutes later - and 92% were below M3.0; the M4.2 of 13 August is the second. No aftershock has come close to the mainshock in size. Ninety-six of the 147 lie at 60 km depth or more within 80 km of the epicentre: that subset is the intraslab sequence itself, and its cumulative curve tracks the SGC's published totals. The remainder is background seismicity the same catalogue records, which is why a raw count runs ahead of the official figure. A modest, quickly-decaying sequence is what an intermediate-depth rupture is expected to produce - but the 13 August event shows that shaking able to stop rescue work continues.



147 SGC-located events after the mainshock (ADRC, from the SGC catalogue)

How much the agencies differ

More than 30 agencies published a solution for the mainshock within minutes. Their magnitudes span Mw 7.0-7.7 and their depths 74-121 km; several automatic solutions defaulted to 10 km before revision. This report uses the USGS/NEIC solution (Mw 7.4, 110 km), which matches PAGER v5, and shows the SGC solution beside it. The spread is normal for a deep event recorded at teleseismic distances, and it is the reason early media figures for depth and magnitude disagreed.

Data: SGC catalogue extract for the region, 10 Aug 07:34 to 11 Aug 17:24 COT, 148 rows including the mainshock, each with an SGC event id and reviewed ("manual") status; supplied by the author and held in this repository as images/sgc_aftershocks.csv. Both panels are generated from that file, so the figure can be reproduced and each event checked against sgc.gov.co by its id. The extract's mainshock row (103 km at 4.99 N 76.29 W) matches the SGC event page as revised on 11 August, which is a check on the extract as a whole.

Sources: [Servicio Geológico Colombiano \(SGC\)](#) · [Semana — SGC total: 103 aftershocks to 15:00 on 11 Aug](#) · [El Tiempo — 99 aftershocks and their magnitudes \(SGC\)](#) · [USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia \(event page\)](#)

Human Damage

Deaths

273

Injured

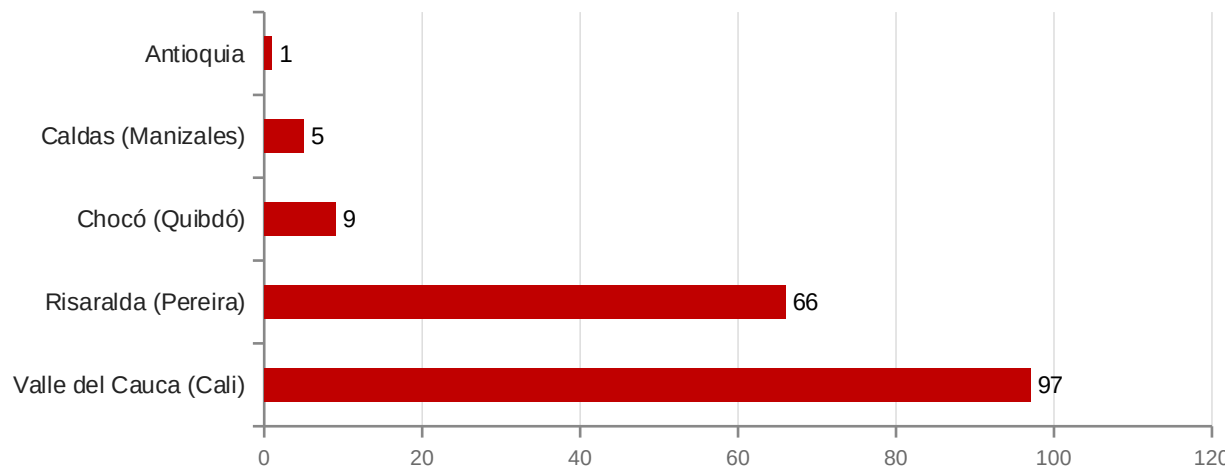
3,824

Missing

377

UNGRD balance given by its director on the morning of 13 August. 40,753 families (97,515 people) affected; 12,584 homes destroyed and 74,873 damaged. Missing fell from 496 to 377 because the count is now the Fiscalía's official register and duplicate reports have been reconciled against it.

Reported deaths by department (provisional)



Department	Deaths	Note
Valle del Cauca (Cali)	97	President, 11 Aug. The department government's count is higher: 95 in Cali plus 35 in other municipalities
Risaralda (Pereira)	66	President, 11 Aug. The department reports around 90
Chocó (Quibdó)	9	Four children still missing under a collapsed school in Quibdó
Caldas (Manizales)	5	Reported as 2, then 4, then 5
Antioquia	1	73-year-old

Reading the numbers

The national figure reached 273 on the morning of 13 August, from UNGRD's balance; Medicina Legal has received 250 bodies and recognised 227 of them. Earlier readings were 265 on the evening of 12 August, 239 earlier that day, 254 from summing departmental and city announcements, and 234 from Asocapitales for the capital cities alone. Cite 273 as the official national figure and 250 as the forensically confirmed floor. The chart is the President's 11 August breakdown (181) and shows the shape of the distribution - deaths concentrated in Risaralda (Pereira) and Valle del Cauca (Cali) - not a current tally. Cali is reported three ways as well: 97 in the President's breakdown, 85 by the mayor on 11 August and 69 in the city's own municipal report, which carries no cut-off time.

Sources: [Noticias Caracol — UNGRD balance: 182 deaths, 2,542 injured, 189 missing](#) · [RPP — the President's 181 is 59 fewer than the regional data](#) · [El Tiempo — live updates, 11 August \(Cali toll rises to 85\)](#) · [Asocapitales balance — 132 deaths, 570+ injured, by city](#)

Missing Persons: two counts

Reported to the authorities

377

Unresolved on the citizen platform

3,653

Located through the platform

429

Two different “missing” numbers

377 and 3,653 are not the same measure and neither is wrong. 377 is the official register held by the Fiscalía General de la Nación as reported by UNGRD on the morning of 13 August; it fell from 496 the previous evening not because those people were found but because duplicate and resolved reports were reconciled against the register. 3,653 is the number of people on the citizen platform “Colombia te busca” whom families have registered and not yet found - a community initiative, not a state register, which does not replace a report to the police or the prosecutor's office and will contain duplicates and people simply out of contact where power and telephone service are down. Expect both figures to move in steps rather than smoothly. Cite 377 as the missing count; cite 3,653 as the volume of family enquiries, which is the better measure of how many households do not yet know.

The registrations cluster in Valle del Cauca, Risaralda, Caldas and Chocó - the same four departments that hold the deaths. Asocapitales, the association of capital cities, has launched a second platform, so the enquiry volume is now split across two registers and the totals should not be added together.

Cali: municipal damage report

Officials of the Alcaldía de Santiago de Cali. City figures; they are not a subset of any national cut-off.

Deaths

69

Injured

1,008

People trapped

230

People rescued

88

Item	Reported
Buildings collapsed	107
Buildings with structural damage	643
Buildings under evacuation order	18
People trapped	230
People rescued	88
Deaths	69
Injured	1,008

Reading these against the other Cali figures

The city's own count of 69 deaths sits below the 85 the mayor gave on 11 August and the 97 in the President's breakdown the same day, and its 1,008 injured sits above the mayor's 885. The municipal report carries no cut-off time, so it cannot be placed in that sequence: it may be an earlier snapshot, or a narrower count of deaths confirmed by the city itself. Until the city states its cut-off, cite the national figures for the national picture and use these for what only the municipality reports - collapsed and structurally damaged buildings, evacuation orders, and the trapped-versus-rescued balance.

230 people trapped against 88 rescued is the number that drives the next 48 hours in Cali: it is the search-and-rescue caseload, and it is larger than the city's death toll.

Officials of the Alcaldía de Santiago de Cali, received 12 August 2026

Sources: [Alcaldía de Santiago de Cali — disaster risk management](#) · [El Tiempo — live updates, 11 August \(Cali toll rises to 85\)](#) · [UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management](#)

Damage: Buildings, Services & Lifelines (1/3)

All figures preliminary. Official (government) figures are primary; media-sourced items are labelled.

Item	Reported	Source	Tier
Deaths	273 (UNGRD, morning of 13 Aug), up from 265 on the evening of 12 Aug. Medicina Legal has received 250 bodies, of which 227 have been recognised.	UNGRD, 13 Aug; Medicina Legal	Official
Injured	3,824 (UNGRD, morning of 13 Aug), up from 3,494 the previous evening	UNGRD, 13 Aug	Official
Missing (reported to the authorities)	377 (UNGRD, morning of 13 Aug), down from 496 the previous evening. The count is now the official register held by the Fiscalía General de la Nación, and the fall reflects reports being reconciled against it rather than people being found.	UNGRD / Fiscalía General de la Nación, 13 Aug	Official
Unresolved reports on citizen platforms	4,084 people registered on “Colombia te busca”, of whom 3,653 are still to be located and 429 have been found - concentrated in Valle del Cauca, Risaralda, Caldas and Chocó. Asocapitales has launched a second platform.	“Colombia te busca” (citizen initiative); Asocapitales	Media
Rescued alive	243 (as of 20:00 COT on 11 Aug), including a woman recovered in Cali almost 30 hours after the earthquake and a baby pulled from an apartment block	Provisional national balance, 12 Aug	Official
Municipalities affected	403 municipalities across 14 departments (UNGRD, 12 Aug), against “more than 20” on 10 Aug. Red alert continues in Cali, Pereira, Quibdó, Manizales and Armenia.	UNGRD, 12 Aug	Official
People affected	40,753 families - 97,515 people - directly affected (UNGRD, morning of 13 Aug), against 25,872 families (53,816 people) the previous evening	UNGRD, 13 Aug	Official

Sources: [UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management](#) · [Colombia One - First official assessment: widespread structural damage](#) · [CNN — live updates: death toll rises to 132](#)

Damage: Buildings, Services & Lifelines (2/3)

All figures preliminary. Official (government) figures are primary; media-sourced items are labelled.

Item	Reported	Source	Tier
Homes damaged or destroyed	87,457: 12,584 destroyed and 74,873 damaged (UNGRD, morning of 13 Aug), against 64,873 the previous evening	UNGRD, 13 Aug	Official
of which seriously damaged	74,873	UNGRD, 13 Aug	Official
of which destroyed	12,584	UNGRD, 13 Aug	Official
Buildings collapsed	172 nationally (UNGRD, 13 Aug), against 140 the previous evening and 61 on 10 Aug. Asocapitales counts 243 collapsed structures in the capital cities; Cali city officials report 107 collapsed and 643 structurally damaged.	UNGRD, 13 Aug; Asocapitales; Alcaldía de Cali	Official
Health facilities	216 damaged (UNGRD, 13 Aug), up from 93 on 11 Aug and 18 on 10 Aug; 7 health institutions closed; about 30% of the University Hospital in Cali collapsed, including three floors (paediatrics, internal medicine, part of the neonatal unit)	UNGRD, 13 Aug; Valle del Cauca government	Official
Educational facilities	2,198 affected (UNGRD, 13 Aug), against 1,819 the previous evening and 52 on 10 Aug	UNGRD, 13 Aug	Official
Community facilities	825 damaged (UNGRD, 13 Aug), against 631 the previous evening	UNGRD, 13 Aug	Official

Sources: [UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management](#) · [Colombia One - First official assessment: widespread structural damage](#) · [CNN — live updates: death toll rises to 132](#)

Damage: Buildings, Services & Lifelines (3/3)

All figures preliminary. Official (government) figures are primary; media-sourced items are labelled.

Item	Reported	Source	Tier
Roads	77 roads damaged (UNGRD, 11 Aug), up from 18 on 10 Aug	UNGRD, 11 Aug	Official
Airports	5 airports with damage in the UNGRD balance of 13 Aug; operations had been suspended at seven. Matecaña International (Pereira) passenger terminal partially collapsed; flights suspended at Pereira, Manizales, Quibdó, Armenia, Cartago and Buenaventura	UNGRD, 13 Aug; civil aviation authority	Official
Cultural heritage	A tower of the neo-Gothic Cathedral of Manizales collapsed onto the nave	Mayor of Manizales	Media
Lifelines	71 aqueducts damaged and 29 banking offices out of service (UNGRD, 13 Aug); power outages and communications disruption reported in areas near the epicentre	UNGRD, 13 Aug	Media
Displacement	Thousands reported to have left their homes; shelter figures not yet published	Media / humanitarian agencies	Media

Sources: [UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management](#) · [Colombia One - First official assessment: widespread structural damage](#) · [CNN — live updates: death toll rises to 132](#)

National Response



[Official] National disaster declaration activating the National Disaster Risk Management System (SNGRD) under Law 1523 of 2012.

[Official] Unified Command Post (PMU) established in Chocó; UNGRD coordinating with departmental and municipal risk-management councils.

[Official] Four USAR teams (Bogotá, Envigado, Yopal, Medellín) deployed for search and rescue in collapsed structures.

[Official] Armed forces deployed for search, rescue, route clearance and security in the affected departments.

[Official] Rapid structural inspection of hospitals, schools and airports; seven health institutions closed and six airports suspended pending assessment.

[Media] Patients transferred from the damaged University Hospital in Cali to other facilities; the city reported casualties concentrated at 12 critical collapse sites.

[Official] The President toured the affected regions on 11-12 August - Quibdó, then Cali, then Pereira, Dosquebradas, Manizales and Armenia - and said he would direct the response from the field rather than Bogotá.

[Official] Relief measures announced during the tour: three months of relief on public-utility bills for households registered as affected, a rent subsidy for those who lost their homes, a census and characterisation of damaged housing ahead of repairs, and a shock plan for education and housing. On the evening of 12 August the President announced the declaration of an economic emergency, a constitutional mechanism intended to speed up the response.



President Abelardo de la Espriella chairs the national response meeting © UNGRD
— <https://portal.gestiondelriesgo.gov.co/>



Cali fire service at a collapsed building in the city © Alcaldía de Santiago de Cali
— <https://www.cali.gov.co/gestiondelriesgo/>

Legal basis

The national disaster declaration activates the SNGRD established by Law 1523 of 2012, allowing UNGRD to direct resources and the national disaster fund (FNGRD) to be used without the ordinary procurement timelines.

International Support



[Official] Colombia is taking INSARAG-classified USAR teams from four countries only - the United States, Israel, Ecuador and El Salvador - on the stated grounds that they are internationally certified, work to INSARAG standards under UN coordination, and are fully self-sufficient, so they place no additional burden on municipal administrations. Their role is to support the Colombian USAR teams already deployed. The Government denied reports that other offers were declined for ideological reasons; the selection has nonetheless been questioned in the Colombian press.

[Official] On 12 August Colombia accepted international search-and-rescue assistance, from countries whose teams meet the INSARAG classification: Israel, Ecuador, El Salvador and the United States. At Colombia's request the US State Department mobilised the Fairfax County (Virginia) and Los Angeles County (California) USAR task forces. El Salvador sent 100 tonnes of relief supplies and a Mexican aid flight has arrived.

[Official] United States: USD 15.5 million in emergency assistance announced on 10 August, for emergency shelter, food, protection and damage assessment.

[Official] European Union: the EU Civil Protection Mechanism was activated and an initial EUR 100,000 in humanitarian funding released, channelled through the German Red Cross, whose teams were already in the country. Copernicus was placed at the disposal of the Colombian authorities and the EU consular crisis mechanism was activated for EU citizens in the affected area. The Commission President and the High Representative stated the EU is ready to provide more if needed.

[Official] Japan: on 11 August at 21:31 JST (07:31 COT) the Prime Minister, Takaichi Sanae, posted condolences - "Japan stands with Colombia in this difficult time". Foreign Minister Motegi issued a message: "In the wake of the earthquake that struck the Republic of Colombia on August 10, I express my deepest condolences to those who lost their lives and extend my heartfelt sympathies to all those affected. The Government of Japan also stands ready to provide the necessary assistance. Japan stands in strong solidarity with the people of Colombia." No dispatch of the Japan Disaster Relief team and no emergency grant aid had been announced at the time of writing.

[Official] Ecuador mobilised a specialised USAR team of 47 personnel with canine units and self-sufficient equipment.

[Media] Offers of assistance were also reported from Chile, Peru, Panama, Argentina, Brazil, Venezuela, Bolivia, Guatemala, Cuba, El Salvador, Spain, Italy, France, Germany, Switzerland, Israel and Ukraine - USAR teams, medical and paramedic personnel, relief items and satellite observation. The CAF development bank announced a USD 500,000 donation.

[Official] Copernicus EMS Rapid Mapping activated as EMSR916 'Earthquake in Colombia' at 17:13 UTC on 10 August (12:13 COT), requested by EC Services / DG ECHO, to provide earthquake damage assessment emergency mapping. Status ongoing, with 3 areas of interest and 3 products at the time of writing. The activation reason names Quibdó, Pereira, Manizales and Cali as cities with significant damage and collapsed buildings.

[Official] United Nations: OCHA stated the humanitarian system is ready to support Colombia, and its preliminary needs analysis names drinking water, hygiene kits and household items, health care, food assistance and shelter. As of 11 August no formal request had been made; on 12 August the Government accepted international search-and-rescue assistance.

[TBC] The International Charter 'Space and Major Disasters' is also reported to have been activated for this earthquake; the activation number had not been confirmed at the time of writing.

[Media] International NGOs mobilising: Direct Relief and Americares (medical supplies), Save the Children (child protection and education), International Rescue Committee (assessment near the epicentre in Chocó), Convoy of Hope (relief goods).

From offers to a filtered acceptance

For two days Colombia took money and satellite mapping but not foreign rescuers, and the UN had no formal request. That changed on 12 August: the Government accepted USAR teams and specified INSARAG classification as the condition, which is the right filter for teams that must be self-sufficient and interoperable. But offers came from at least seventeen countries and four were taken, so INSARAG classification alone does not explain the list - several of the others hold it too. The Government's stated criteria are certification, self-sufficiency and speed; it has denied that ideology played a part, and the argument is now running in the Colombian press. For a reader of this report the operative points are two: under Ley 1523 the response is Colombia's to direct, and a receiving country that narrows the field this far should expect to explain the basis in writing.

Sources: [El Tiempo — SAR teams arriving from Israel, Ecuador, El Salvador and the US](#) · [El Tiempo — list of countries that have offered assistance](#) · [UN in Colombia — earthquake information and updates](#) · [Copernicus EMS — EMSR916 'Earthquake in Colombia' \(activation\)](#)

Satellite & Analytical Support

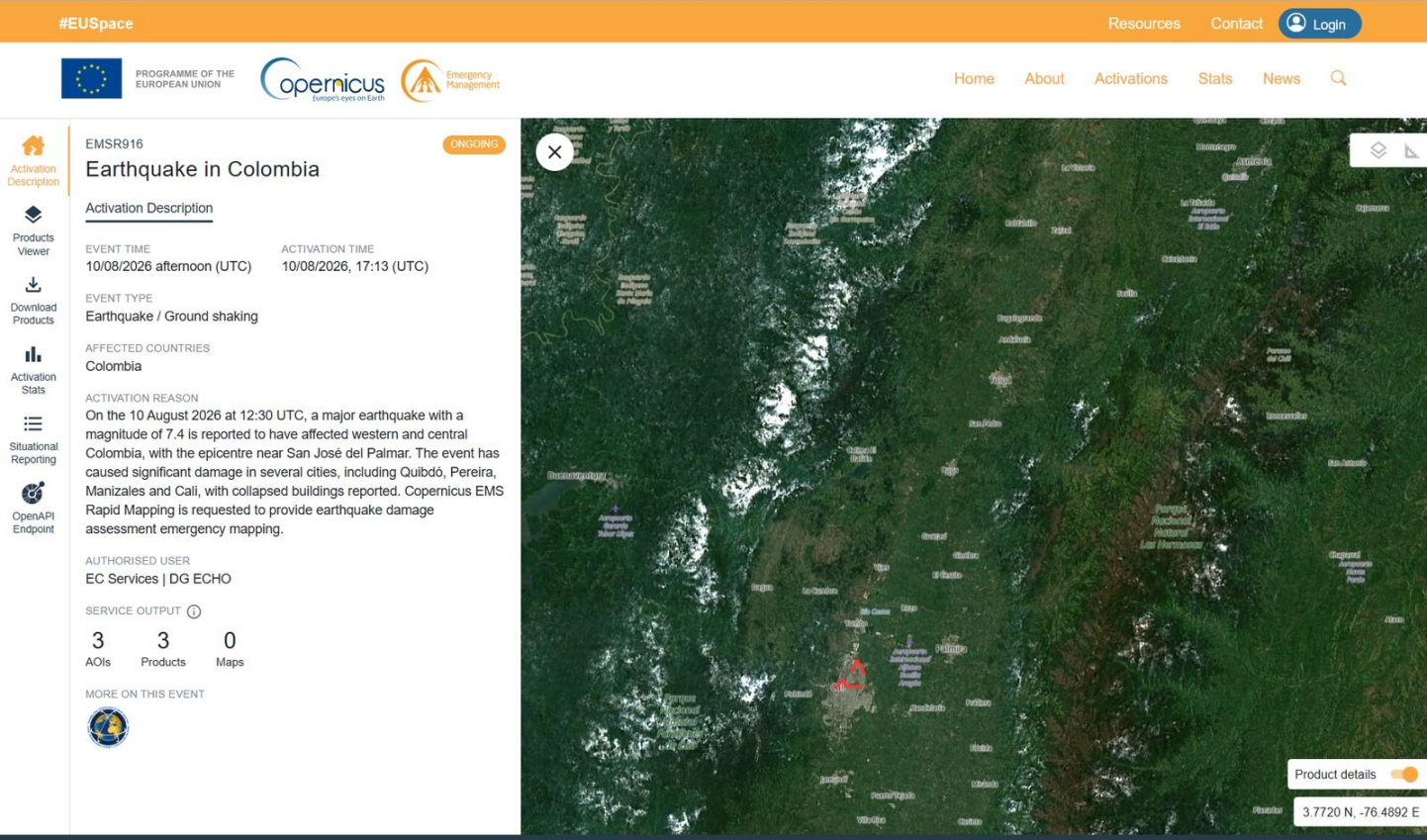
Organisation	Contribution	Status	Tier
International Charter	Activation for the Colombia earthquake reported; wide-area optical/SAR imagery for damage assessment	Reported / number pending	TBC
Copernicus EMS	EMSR916 'Earthquake in Colombia' — Rapid Mapping for damage assessment; requested by EC Services / DG ECHO; 3 AOIs, 3 products	Ongoing (EMSR916)	Official
USGS	ShakeMap, PAGER (Orange), finite-fault and aftershock catalogue	Published	Official
GDACS	Overall Orange alert; population exposure and impact estimates	Published	Official
SGC	National seismic network: hypocentre, magnitude revision, aftershock bulletins, accelerographic records	Published	Official
Sentinel Asia	Not applicable - the mechanism covers the Asia-Pacific region; Colombia is served by the International Charter and Copernicus EMS	n/a	Official

Note on Sentinel Asia

Sentinel Asia, for which ADRC serves as a joint project team member, covers the Asia-Pacific region. For a disaster in Colombia the equivalent international mechanisms are the International Charter 'Space and Major Disasters' and the Copernicus Emergency Management Service; UNOSAT/UNITAR rapid mapping is also commonly used in Latin America.

Sources: [International Charter 'Space and Major Disasters' - activations](#) · [Copernicus EMS — EMSR916 'Earthquake in Colombia' \(activation\)](#) · [GDACS - Orange earthquake alert, Colombia, 10 Aug 2026](#)

Copernicus EMS Rapid Mapping: EMSR916



Activation page (© Copernicus EMS) — <https://mapping.emergency.copernicus.eu/activations/EMSR916/>

Item	Value
Activation	EMSR916 — Earthquake in Colombia
Event time	10/08/2026 afternoon (UTC)
Activation time	10/08/2026, 17:13 (UTC) = 12:13 COT
Event type	Earthquake / Ground shaking
Affected country	Colombia
Authorised user	EC Services DG ECHO
Service output	3 AOIs · 3 products · 0 maps
Status	ONGOING

Activation reason (verbatim)
“On the 10 August 2026 at 12:30 UTC, a major earthquake with a magnitude of 7.4 is reported to have affected western and central Colombia, with the epicentre near San José del Palmar. The event has caused significant damage in several cities, including Quibdó, Pereira, Manizales and Cali, with collapsed buildings reported. Copernicus EMS Rapid Mapping is requested to provide earthquake damage assessment emergency mapping.”

What Rapid Mapping delivers
Rapid Mapping delivers reference and grading products over selected areas of interest, not nationwide coverage. Products are published on the activation page as they are produced and are free to use.

Colombia's Disaster Risk Management System

Colombia rebuilt its disaster risk management framework after the 1985 Armero volcanic disaster and again after the 1999 Armenia earthquake. Law 1523 of 2012 created the National Disaster Risk Management System (SNGRD), led by the National Unit for Disaster Risk Management (UNGRD), which reports to the Presidency.

- Law 1523 of 2012 - national policy on disaster risk management; defines the SNGRD and makes risk management a mandatory duty of every public authority and, in part, of private actors.
- UNGRD - national coordinating agency under the Presidency; runs the national response, the disaster fund (FNGRD) and the national information system.
- Departmental and municipal risk management councils (CDGRD / CMGRD) carry out first response; UNGRD reinforces when local capacity is exceeded.
- PNGRD 2015-2030 — the national disaster risk management plan, adopted by Decree 308 of 2016 and updated by Decree 1478 of 3 August 2022; aligned with the Sendai Framework and monitored annually by UNGRD.
- NSR-10 - the national seismic building code (in force since 2010, technical annexes updated since). Buildings predating modern code enforcement, and non-engineered masonry and earthen construction, remain the dominant source of risk.
- Seismic microzonation studies exist for major cities including Bogotá, Medellín, Cali, Pereira, Manizales and Armenia — a direct legacy of the 1999 earthquake. In Cali the microzonation is binding on structural design through Decree 411.0.20.0158 of 2014.
- The SGC operates the National Seismological Network and the national accelerograph network, and issues public bulletins within minutes.
- Cities run their own instruments alongside the national system: Cali's SATIC community-and-sensor early warning system (from 2018, formalised by Municipal Decree 0858 of 2022), Medellín's DAGRD and its municipal plan, and municipal risk-management funds created under Law 1523.

The 1999 Armenia (Quindío) Earthquake & Recovery

The 1999 Armenia (Quindío) Earthquake - the same Coffee Region

On 25 January 1999 an M6.1-6.2 earthquake at about 30 km depth struck the Quindío coffee-growing region. It killed about 1,185 people, injured over 5,000 and damaged or destroyed some 50,000 structures; roughly 60% of the buildings in the city of Armenia collapsed or were severely damaged, and more than 200,000 people were displaced. Although far smaller in magnitude than the 2026 event, it was much shallower and much closer to the cities, which is why its local destructiveness was far greater.

1999 impact	Figure
Deaths	approx. 1,185
Injured	over 5,000
Structures damaged or destroyed	approx. 50,000
Displaced	over 200,000
Coffee sector	approx. 8,000 farms and 1,200 processing facilities damaged

What followed / lessons

- Reconstruction was managed through a dedicated temporary body for the Coffee Region, an early example in Latin America of a purpose-built reconstruction agency.
- The disaster drove enforcement of the national seismic code and the seismic microzonation studies that now cover Pereira, Manizales and Armenia.
- Recovery of the coffee economy took roughly a decade - the economic tail of the disaster far outlasted the emergency phase.
- The 2026 earthquake shook the same cities, but as a deep, distant source rather than a shallow local one: a different loading of the same building stock.

Why this matters now

The cities hit hardest in 2026 - Pereira, Manizales, Armenia - are the same cities that rebuilt after 1999. How that rebuilt stock performed under long-period, long-duration shaking from a 110 km-deep source is the key question for post-event assessment.

Pre-event Risk Assessment: Santiago de Cali

Cali did not lack a risk assessment. Between 2020 and 2022 the city built a full urban earthquake risk model with the GEM Foundation under the USAID-supported TREQ project, one of three pilot cities alongside Quito and Santiago de los Caballeros. The modelled scenario is a shallow local one — magnitude 6.5 at 10 km depth on the Dagua-Calima fault — and its estimates dwarf what the city actually experienced on 10 August 2026.

Modelled scenario (GEM-TREQ, 2022)	Value
Modelled scenario	M6.5, 10 km depth, Dagua-Calima fault, urban area
Population exposed	approx. 2,300,000
Estimated deaths	approx. 1,200
Seriously injured	approx. 36,300
Displaced	approx. 181,000
Buildings collapsed	approx. 1,800 of 348,000 (0.5%)
Residual risk	assessed at about 40% after existing measures

Figures from the GEM-TREQ urban risk assessment for Santiago de Cali and from the city's local disaster risk management plan, as compiled by the Municipality of Santiago de Cali (Secretaría de Gestión del Riesgo de Emergencias y Desastres) for a JICA training course.

The 2026 earthquake was not this scenario

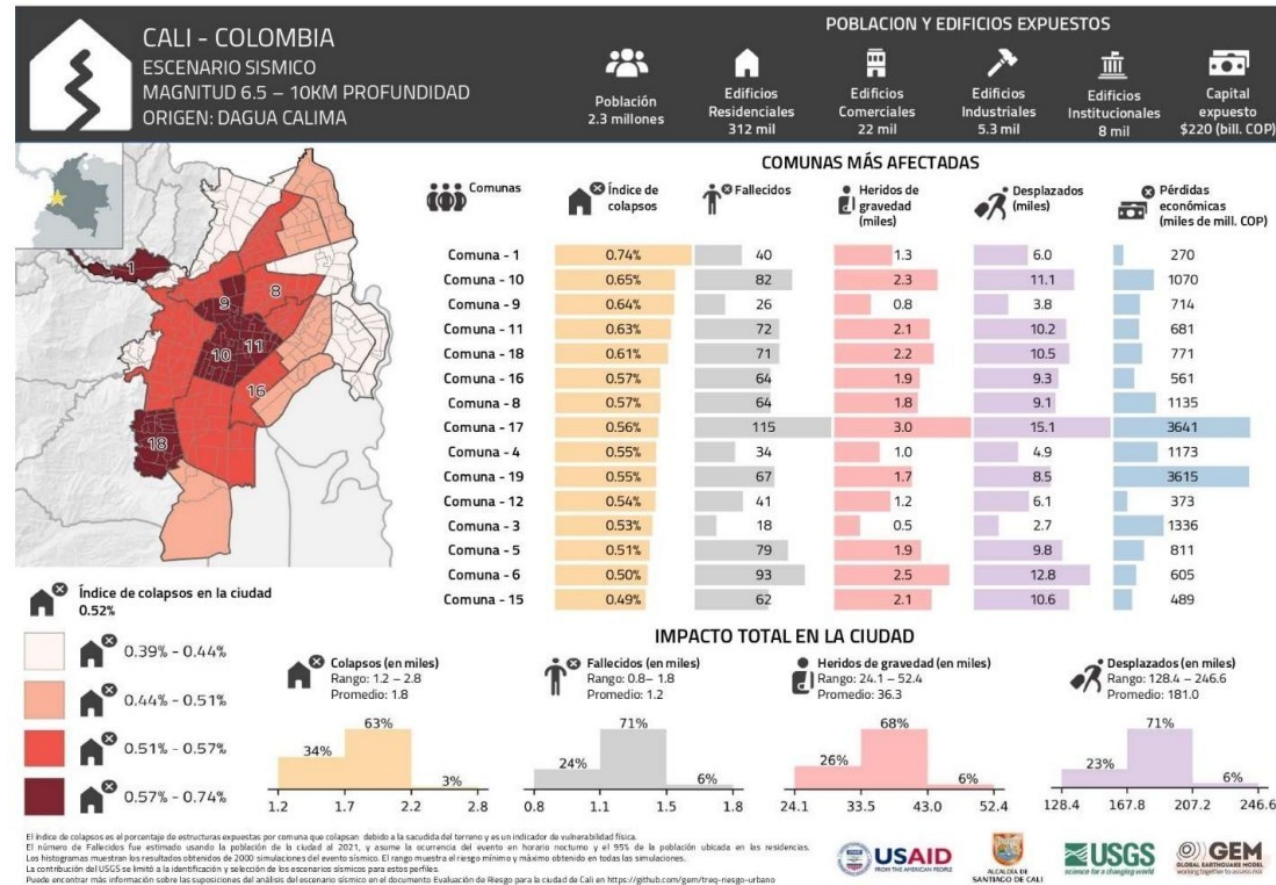
The 10 August event was larger in magnitude (M7.4) but 110 km deep and 158 km from Cali, giving the city MMI VI rather than the near-field shaking of the modelled M6.5. Cali recorded 27 deaths and 25-30 collapsed structures — two orders of magnitude below the scenario. What it did test is exactly the weakness the local plan had flagged: about 30% of the University Hospital collapsed and seven health institutions closed. The city's own worst case remains ahead of it, and the case for retrofitting indispensable buildings is now evidential rather than theoretical.

What the city had already prioritised

- Seismic vulnerability studies of indispensable buildings — hospitals, schools, fire stations — to the NSR-10 code (budgeted at about USD 1.7 million, short term).
- Structural retrofitting of indispensable buildings and of basic-service infrastructure, to keep essential services running after an earthquake.
- Seismic vulnerability assessment of the EMCALI water, sewerage and power networks and of the city gas network.
- Updating the local soil-response model and the seismic microzonation, in force since INGEOMINAS/DAGMA (2005) and adopted by Decree 411.0.20.0158 of 2014 for structural design.
- Maintaining and extending the Cali accelerograph network (RAC) and its interoperability with the SGC national network.
- Insuring public infrastructure against seismic risk, and retrofitting low-income housing through subsidies and safe self-build programmes.
- Financing model for the priority measures: local government 30-50%, national disaster fund (FNGRD/UNGRD) 30-50%, international partners including JICA, the GEM Foundation and the IDB about 20%.

Sources: [GEM Foundation — TREQ project \(urban earthquake risk, Quito / Cali / Santiago de los Caballeros\)](#) · [GEM-TREQ — Evaluación de riesgo sísmico para Santiago de Cali \(technical report D2.6.2\)](#) · [Alcaldía de Santiago de Cali — disaster risk management](#)

GEM-TREQ City Profile: Cali



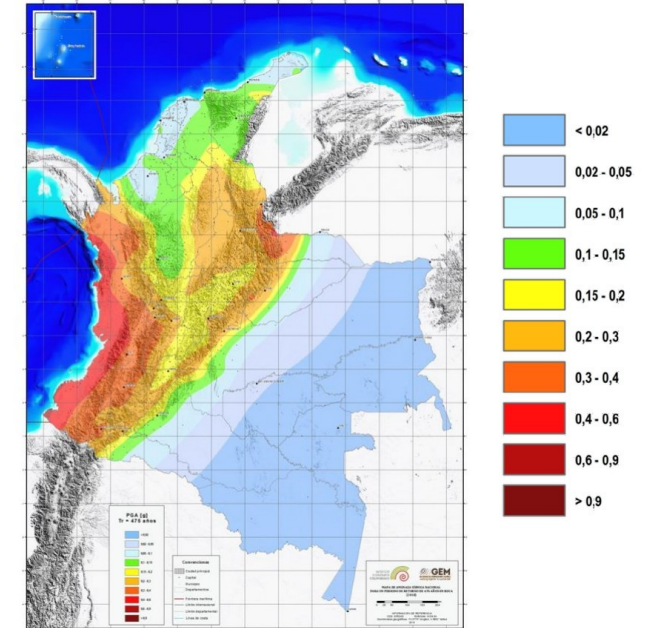
© GEM Foundation / USAID / Alcaldía de Santiago de Cali / USGS — <https://github.com/gem/treq-riesgo-urbano>

GEM-TREQ city profile for Cali: the M6.5 / 10 km Dagua-Calima scenario. 2.3 million people and 312,000 residential, 22,000 commercial, 5,300 industrial and 8,000 institutional buildings are exposed, with COP 220 trillion of exposed capital. The bars give, per comuna, the collapse index, fatalities, serious injuries, displaced people and economic losses; the histograms give the city totals with their modelled ranges.

Sources: [GEM-TREQ — Evaluación de riesgo sísmico para Santiago de Cali \(technical report D2.6.2\)](#) · [GEM Foundation — TREQ project \(urban earthquake risk, Quito / Cali / Santiago de los Caballeros\)](#)

Historical Earthquakes in Colombia

Year	Event	Mag.	Impact
1906	Ecuador-Colombia earthquake (Pacific coast)	M8.8	One of the largest earthquakes ever recorded; destructive tsunami on the Pacific coast
1925	Cali earthquake (Valle del Cauca)	M7.0	The reference historical event for Cali; the city was also shaken in 1995 and 2004, the latter damaging clinics and residential buildings
1938	Coffee Region earthquake (deep, 150 km)	M7.0	An intermediate-depth event beneath the same coffee-growing departments — the closest historical analogue to the 2026 earthquake
1979	Tumaco earthquake (Nariño)	M8.1	Subduction-interface event with tsunami; several hundred deaths
1983	Popayán earthquake (Cauca)	M5.5	About 250-300 deaths; historic city centre heavily damaged - a small but shallow, urban event
1994	Páez (Cauca) earthquake	M6.8	About 1,100 deaths, most caused by earthquake-triggered landslides and debris flows
1995	Chocó earthquake	M6.6	Intermediate-depth event in the same department as the 2026 earthquake
1999	Armenia (Quindío) earthquake	M6.1-6.2	About 1,185 deaths; Colombia's costliest earthquake disaster; drove the modern DRM reforms
2026	Chocó earthquake (this event)	M7.4	Largest magnitude recorded in Colombia in the past decade (SGC); intermediate depth, wide-area damage



PGA (g), SGC / GEM national seismic hazard model (2020)
[— https://amenazasismica.sgc.gov.co/](https://amenazasismica.sgc.gov.co/)

National seismic hazard, 475-year return period

Pattern

Colombia's deadliest earthquakes have not been its largest. Popayán 1983 (M5.5), Páez 1994 (M6.8) and Armenia 1999 (M6.1-6.2) were all shallow and close to towns; the largest events, offshore in 1906 and 1979, killed fewer people. Depth and proximity, not magnitude alone, drive the toll.

Sources: [USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia \(event page\)](#) · [Servicio Geológico Colombiano \(SGC\)](#) · [GEM Foundation — TREQ project \(urban earthquake risk, Quito / Cali / Santiago de los Caballeros\)](#)

Observations & Points to Watch

[Official] A deep source with shallow-disaster consequences. At 110 km depth the earthquake produced no surface rupture and no tsunami, yet it damaged buildings in at least six departments. Damage is dispersed rather than concentrated, which complicates needs assessment, logistics and the targeting of search and rescue.

[Official] Critical facilities failed. The collapse of about 30% of Cali's University Hospital, the closure of seven health institutions, damage to 52 schools and the partial collapse of an international airport terminal all reduce response capacity exactly where it is needed. Seismic performance of hospitals, schools and transport terminals is the clearest lesson emerging so far.

[Official] The toll multiplied as the assessment reached the damage. In 56 hours deaths went from 111 to 239, injured from 87 to 3,755, missing from none counted to 287, damaged homes from 1,612 to about 54,000, and the affected area from "more than 20 municipalities" to 403 across 14 departments. Nothing new happened to cause those jumps; the assessment reached places it had not reached, and much of Chocó is still accessible only by boat or aircraft. Two lessons for reading early figures: the first-day numbers describe the reach of the assessment, not the size of the disaster; and where two counts of the same thing exist, check what each is counting before comparing them.

[Media] The affected area is the Coffee Region rebuilt after 1999. Comparing how post-1999 construction performed against older stock, under a very different type of shaking, will be valuable for the region and for other countries with intermediate-depth seismic sources.

[Official] The assessments existed before the event. Cali's GEM-TREQ risk model and its local plan had already named hospitals and other indispensable buildings as the priority to retrofit, and the 2026 earthquake — a far weaker test than the city's own modelled scenario — still took out roughly 30% of its main public hospital. The gap here is not knowledge but implementation and financing.

[Official] Aftershock risk to damaged buildings. The SGC located 147 events in 34 hours, 92% of them below M3.0 and only one above M4.0 - as modest as an intermediate-depth intraslab rupture predicts. That statistic is not the operational point: the M4.8 of 10 August was felt widely, and the M3.9 of 11 August emptied buildings again in several cities. Structures the mainshock left standing but damaged have lost capacity, so rapid habitability assessment before re-occupancy matters more than the aftershock numbers.

[TBC] Points to watch: the reconciled national casualty figures; shelter and displacement numbers, which have not yet been published; water and power restoration in Chocó; the results of satellite-based damage mapping; and whether the Government requests international assistance beyond the offers already made.

Useful Links & Sources (1/5)

Source policy: Source hierarchy: official > media > TBC. Government and scientific-agency figures are used as primary; media reports are used only where official figures are not yet published and are labelled as such. Items still being verified are marked TBC. Preliminary figures are never replaced by larger unverified numbers.

Source	Tier	URL
USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia (event page)	Official	https://earthquake.usgs.gov/earthquakes/eventpage/us6000tjl2/executive
Servicio Geológico Colombiano (SGC)	Official	https://www.sgc.gov.co/
SGC — event bulletin SGC2026pqqmro (this earthquake)	Official	https://www.sgc.gov.co/detallesismo/SGC2026pqqmro/
SGC — macroseismic intensity map (ShakeMap) for this earthquake	Official	https://www.sgc.gov.co/detallesismo/SGC2026pqqmro/mmi
UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management	Official	https://portal.gestiondelriesgo.gov.co/
GDACS - Orange earthquake alert, Colombia, 10 Aug 2026	Official	https://gdacs.org/report.aspx?eventid=1557236&eventtype=EQ
International Charter 'Space and Major Disasters' - activations	Official	https://disasterscharter.org/activations
Copernicus EMS — EMSR916 'Earthquake in Colombia' (activation)	Official	https://mapping.emergency.copernicus.eu/activations/EMSR916/
ReliefWeb - Colombia	Official	https://reliefweb.int/country/col
PAHO/WHO - Colombia	Official	https://www.paho.org/en/colombia
PreventionWeb - Colombia PNGRD 2015-2030	Official	https://www.preventionweb.net/publication/colombia-plan-nacional-de-gestion-del-riesgo-de-desastres-pngrd-2015-2030
GEM - Seismic regulations for Colombia (NSR-10)	Official	https://www.globalquakemodel.org/seismic-regulations/colombia
CNN — live updates: death toll rises to 132	Media	https://www.cnn.com/2026/08/10/world/live-news/colombia-earthquake-san-jose-del-palmar

Useful Links & Sources (2/5)

Source	Tier	URL
El Colombiano — 84 injured and 12 dead in Chocó (department government)	Media	https://www.elcolombiano.com/colombia/terremoto-temblor-hoy-colombia-choco-heridos-FL39761141
UN-SPIDER - UNGRD of Colombia	Official	https://un-spider.org/national-unit-disaster-risk-management-ungrd-colombia
OECD - Risk governance scan of Colombia	Official	https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/risk-governance-scan-of-colombia_eeb81954-en.html
CNN - Live updates: at least 111 dead	Media	https://www.cnn.com/2026/08/10/world/live-news/colombia-earthquake-san-jose-del-palmar
France 24 - Colombia declares national emergency as quake toll hits 111	Media	https://www.france24.com/en/americas/20260810-powerful-quake-rocks-colombia-causing-major-damage
Al Jazeera - M7.4 earthquake hits Colombia	Media	https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/10/7-4-magnitude-earthquake-hits-colombia-killing-at-least-20
CBS News - Strong earthquake strikes western Colombia	Media	https://www.cbsnews.com/news/colombia-earthquake-western-region-evacuations/
NBC News - Deaths, injuries and collapsed buildings	Media	https://www.nbcnews.com/world/latin-america/strong-earthquake-colombia-ecuador-people-evacuating-homes-buildings-rcna591709
Colombia One - First official assessment: widespread structural damage	Media	https://colombiaone.com/2026/08/10/earthquake-colombia-official-details/
Colombia One - Government declares national disaster	Media	https://colombiaone.com/2026/08/10/colombia-national-disaster/
Infobae - SGC explains why the shaking lasted so long	Media	https://www.infobae.com/colombia/2026/08/10/por-que-el-temblor-en-colombia-de-este-lunes-10-de-agosto-duro-una-eternidad-el-servicio-geologico-explico-que-paso/
NHK - President reports 111 dead, 87 injured (Japanese)	Media	https://www3.nhk.or.jp/news/
Nikkei - M7.4 earthquake in western Colombia (Japanese)	Media	https://www.nikkei.com/article/DGXZQOGN108V30Q6A810C2000000/

Useful Links & Sources (3/5)

Source	Tier	URL
Jiji Press - M7.4 earthquake in Colombia (Japanese)	Media	https://www.jiji.com/jc/article?k=2026081000878&g=int
Save the Children - Children at risk after the earthquake	Media	https://www.savethechildren.org/us/about-us/media-and-news/2026-press-releases/children-at-risk-after-earthquake-strike-s-colombia
Direct Relief - Mobilising medical aid	Media	https://www.directrelief.org/2026/08/colombia-earthquake-7-4-magnitude-direct-relief-response/
Americares - Colombia earthquake, August 2026	Media	https://www.americares.org/crisis-alerts/colombia-earthquake-august-2026/
GLIDEnumber — EQ-2026-000146-COL (event identifier)	Official	https://glidenumber.net/
ADRC - Asian Disaster Reduction Center	Official	https://www.adrc.asia/
European Commission — EU support for Colombia, Copernicus activated	Media	https://www.democrata.es/en/international/von-der-leyen-expresses-the-eu-s-support-for-colombia-and-activates-copernicus-after-the-earthquake/
GEM Foundation — TREQ project (urban earthquake risk, Quito / Cali / Santiago de los Caballeros)	Official	https://www.globalquakemodel.org/proj/treq
GEM-TREQ — Evaluación de riesgo sísmico para Santiago de Cali (technical report D2.6.2)	Official	https://cloud-storage.globalquakemodel.org/public/wix-new-website/pdf-collections-wix/publications/TREQ%20deliverables/reports/TREQ_D262_Riesgo_Sismico_Cali_v1.00.pdf
Understanding seismic risk in Santiago de Cali for its application in risk management (peer-reviewed, 2025)	Official	https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S2212420925003097
SATIC — Cali's intelligent and community early warning system	Official	https://satic.cali.gov.co/satic
Alcaldía de Santiago de Cali — disaster risk management	Official	https://www.cali.gov.co/gestiondelriesgo/
UNGRD — Plan Nacional de Gestión del Riesgo de Desastres (PNGRD)	Official	https://portal.gestiondelriesgo.gov.co/Paginas/Plan-Nacional-de-Gestion-del-Riesgo.aspx

Useful Links & Sources (4/5)

Source	Tier	URL
Decreto 1478 de 2022 — update of the PNGRD	Official	https://www.funcionpublica.gov.co/eva/gestornormativo/norma.php?i=191411
EMSC-CSEM SeismicPortal — bulletin and FDSN event service	Official	https://www.emsc-csem.org/
SGC — seismic catalogue viewer (reviewed catalogue ends Feb 2018)	Official	https://catalogosismico.sgc.gov.co/visor/index.html
El Tiempo — live updates, 11 August (Cali toll rises to 85)	Media	https://www.eltiempo.com/colombia/otras-ciudades/terremoto-en-colombia-de-7-4-en-vivo-el-comandante-del-ejercito-nacional-se-encuentra-en-choco-coordinando-las-labores-de-atencion-de-la-emergencia-3577491
Asocapitales balance — 132 deaths, 570+ injured, by city	Media	https://www.elespectador.com/colombia/mas-regiones/temblor-en-colombia-hoy-10-de-agosto-en-vivo-epicentro-y-reporte-de-afectaciones/
Noticias Caracol — UNGRD balance: 182 deaths, 2,542 injured, 189 missing	Media	https://www.noticiascaracol.com/colombia/en-vivo-colombia-hoy-tras-terremoto-de-magnitud-7-4-continuan-las-labores-de-rescate-so35
RPP — the President's 181 is 59 fewer than the regional data	Media	https://rpp.pe/mundo/colombia/abelardo-de-la-espiella-cifra-en-181-los-muertos-por-el-terremoto-59-menos-que-datos-regionales-noticia-1701022
El Tiempo — 99 aftershocks and their magnitudes (SGC)	Media	https://www.eltiempo.com/colombia/otras-ciudades/cuantas-replicas-se-han-registrado-tras-el-terremoto-de-7-4-en-colombia-estas-son-todas-las-magnitudes-3577711
Semana — SGC total: 103 aftershocks to 15:00 on 11 Aug	Media	https://www.semana.com/tecnologia/articulo/servicio-geologico-revela-el-numero-total-de-replicas-que-ha-habido-en-colombia-tras-fuerte-terremoto-que-estremecio-al-pais/202641/
MOFA Japan — Foreign Minister Motegi's message on the earthquake in Colombia	Official	https://www.mofa.go.jp/mofaj/la_c/sa/co/pageit_000001_00001.html
MOFA Japan on X — post of 11 August	Official	https://x.com/MofaJapan_jp/status/2087155064855261537
El Tiempo — list of countries that have offered assistance	Media	https://www.eltiempo.com/mundo/mas-regiones/la-comunidad-internacional-se-vuelca-en-ayudas-para-colombia-lista-de-paises-que-han-ofrecido-apoyo-tras-el-terremoto-de-magnitud-7-3577512
UN in Colombia — earthquake information and updates	Official	https://colombia.un.org/es/320793-informaci%C3%B3n-y-actualizaciones-sobre-el-terremoto-en-colombia

Useful Links & Sources (5/5)

Source	Tier	URL
UN News — the UN offers support to Colombia	Official	https://news.un.org/es/story/2026/08/1541792
“Colombia te busca” — citizen missing-persons platform	Media	https://www.colombiatebusca.com/
Asocapitales — earthquake missing-persons tool	Official	https://www.asocapitales.co/terremoto-colombia.html
Infobae — relief and subsidies announced on the Coffee Region tour	Media	https://www.infobae.com/colombia/2026/08/12/de-la-espriella-anuncio-alivios-y-subsidios-tras-emergencia-en-el-eje-cafetero-por-el-terremoto-detalle-plan-de-choque-para-educacion-y-vivienda/
Pulzo — UNGRD damage and casualty report across 14 departments	Media	https://www.pulzo.com/nacion/terremoto-en-colombia-ungrd-reporta-danos-y-victimas-en-valle-del-cauca-y-risaralda-PP5272829A
El Tiempo — SAR teams arriving from Israel, Ecuador, El Salvador and the US	Media	https://www.eltiempo.com/colombia/otras-ciudades/terremoto-en-colombia-hoy-12-de-agosto-ultimas-noticias-presidente-de-la-espriella-celebro-rescate-de-daniela-largo-tras-36-horas-bajo-los-escombros-3577781
Asocapitales — 188 deaths and 1,677 injured in capital cities	Official	https://www.asocapitales.co/actualidad/noticias/ciudades-seguras/terremoto-deja-188-fallecidos-y-1677-heridos-en-ciudades
infolibre — at least 254 dead as the search continues	Media	https://www.infolibre.es/internacional/terremoto-colombia-deja-254-muertos-continua-busqueda-escombros_1_2235003.html
El Colombiano — 265 dead, 3,494 injured, 496 missing	Media	https://www.elcolombiano.com/colombia/cifra-muertos-heridos-desaparecidos-por-terremoto-colombia-MK39884181
El Tiempo — UNGRD balance of 13 August: 273 dead, 3,824 injured, 377 missing	Media	https://www.eltiempo.com/colombia/otras-ciudades/balance-oficial-de-la-ungrd-tras-terremoto-de-magnitud-7-4-en-colombia-273-fallecidos-3-824-heridos-y-377-desaparecidos-3578196
El Tiempo — 40,753 families affected: UNGRD's new balance	Media	https://www.eltiempo.com/vida/40-753-familias-afectadas-y-273-muertos-ungrd-entrega-nuevo-balance-del-terremoto-en-colombia-3578185
El Tiempo — M4.2 aftershock at San José del Palmar, 13 August	Media	https://www.eltiempo.com/colombia/otras-ciudades/nuevo-temblor-de-magnitud-4-2-se-registro-en-san-jose-del-palmar-choco-en-la-manana-de-este-lunes-13-de-agosto-3578131
Infobae — Colombia to receive rescue teams from the US, Israel, Ecuador and El Salvador	Media	https://www.infobae.com/colombia/2026/08/13/colombia-recibira-equipos-de-rescate-de-ee-uu-israel-ecuador-y-el-salvador-por-terremoto/



Asian Disaster Reduction Center (ADRC)

Bilingual (EN/JA) report for domestic and international dissemination. Public-agency sources take priority; gaps are filled with clearly-labelled media reports.

Figures as of the morning of 13 Aug 2026 COT (evening JST), about 78 hours after the earthquake, from the UNGRD balance given by its director David Santiago Tamayo: 273 deaths, 3,824 injured, 377 missing, 40,753 families (97,515 people) affected, 12,584 homes destroyed and 74,873 damaged, 172 buildings collapsed. An economic emergency has been declared. All figures are preliminary.

<https://www.adrc.asia/>